portrayed Hindu goddesses in the nude. Husain had long been known to use Hindu iconography—goddesses and *apsaras* were among his favourite themes, and he had depicted Indira Gandhi as Durga, and the actress Madhuri Dixit as the *apsara* Menaka, to telling effect in the past, infusing his work with energetic reimaginings of the tales and legends of Hindu tradition. But rather than feeling flattered that a Muslim artist should draw so liberally from the Hindu ethos, the self-appointed custodians of Hindu culture were outraged that he had done so. An irate Hindutva cadre declared that no Muslim had the right to portray Hindu deities 'any way he wishes', going on to demand that Husain's paintings should all be immersed in the Ganga, so they might be simultaneously cleansed and destroyed.

At one time one could have said that this was not Hindu behaviour, and indeed the paintings objected to had been displayed for twenty years previously without any Hindu objecting to them. But this was not about Hinduism, it was about Hindutva politics: the Bajrang Dal and its ilk were practising a basic form of political me-too-ism. Having seen successive governments pandering to the offended sentiments of minority communities, they wanted to show they could be offended too, and thereby bend society to their will.

After the vandalism came the legal harassment of the nonagenarian artist by malicious lawsuits seeking his prosecution for allegedly having offended the petitioners' notions of morality by the use of nudity in his art, particularly in paintings of Hindu goddesses and in the depiction of the contours of India in the shape of a semi-nude female figure. The piling up of a number of cases motivated essentially by anti-Muslim bigotry drove Husain into self-imposed exile in Dubai and London and deprived India of a national treasure. So many abusive cases were filed against him that a court even went so far as to attach his home and his property—a decision later reversed by the Supreme Court. But Husain feared the harassment would not end there; the moment he set foot in Delhi or Mumbai, he said, he was sure to be dragged off to the lock-up, tormented by legal proceedings. He was nearly ninety-one when he fled the country, at an age when he should have been living as a beloved and honoured eminence in his native land. But he did not want to spend his